

TRENESIS

MEAL PLANNING GUIDE

Evidence-based fundamentals for building real, lasting results.

NO FLUFF · NO PSEUDOSCIENCE · JUST RESULTS

BEFORE YOU START

Disclaimer & How to Use This Guide

This guide is for educational purposes only and is based on general nutrition and meal planning principles. It is not intended as medical advice or a substitute for professional healthcare guidance. If you have specific health conditions or dietary needs, consult a qualified healthcare professional.

The information presented is based on current evidence-based nutrition science. Individual results vary based on consistency, training, sleep, and genetics.

How to Use This Guide

- You do not need to follow a strict meal plan or diet. This guide gives you tools and principles – use what works for you.
- Read Chapter 1 to understand what meal planning actually means (it's simpler than you think).
- Go to Chapter 2 to understand how your calorie and protein goals shape your meals.
- Chapters 3 and 4 give practical tips – pick the ones relevant to your goal (fat loss or gaining weight).
- Chapter 5 shows how to put it all together into a simple daily structure.
- Combine with the Trenesis **Nutrition Basics Guide** for the full picture on calories, protein, and macros.

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CHAPTER 01

What Is Meal Planning?

It's just thinking ahead.

The Simple Idea

Meal planning is deciding – in advance – roughly what you'll eat throughout the day. That's it. It doesn't mean eating the same thing every day, cutting out everything you enjoy, or following a rigid schedule. It simply means removing guesswork so that hitting your goals becomes automatic rather than accidental.

When you don't plan, hunger and convenience make your food decisions. When you plan – even loosely – your goals make those decisions instead.

What It Is Not

- A strict diet you have to follow perfectly.
- A requirement to weigh and track every gram of food.
- Something that only works if you prep all your meals on Sunday.
- A system that breaks if you skip a day or eat out.

> **KEY INSIGHT**
>
> A rough plan beats no plan every time. Even knowing what you'll have for breakfast and roughly what's for dinner is enough to make a meaningful difference. Flexibility is a feature, not a flaw.

The Two Numbers That Matter

Meal planning really comes down to two things: getting enough protein and hitting your calorie target. Everything else – meal timing, food variety, exact macros – is secondary. Refer to the Trenesis Nutrition Basics guide for how to calculate your personal targets. Once you have those two numbers, this guide shows you how to structure your day around them.

CHAPTER 02

Planning Around Your Goals

Same principles, different direction.

Two Directions, One Framework

Whether you're trying to lose fat or gain weight, the approach to meal planning is the same: structure your day so you hit your calorie target and get enough protein. The difference is just which direction you're aiming.

GOAL	DAILY STRATEGY
Fat loss	Eat below your TDEE – keep protein high to preserve muscle
Maintenance	Eat roughly equal to your TDEE – focus on protein and food quality.
Muscle Gain	Eat slightly above your TDEE (+200–300 kcal) – prioritise protein and consistency.

Protein First, Always

Regardless of your goal, protein is the priority. Aim for 1.6–2.2 g per kg of bodyweight per day. Plan your meals with protein as the anchor – build carbs and fats around it. This is especially important in a calorie deficit, where adequate protein protects muscle mass.

How Many Meals?

There is no magic number. Most people do well with 3–4 meals a day. The key is distributing protein reasonably evenly rather than consuming almost none at breakfast and a huge amount at dinner. Find a meal frequency that fits your schedule and stick to it.

> **THE TAKEAWAY**
>
> Pick your calorie target and protein goal first. Then plan your day around hitting them. Chapters 3 and 4 give specific strategies based on whether your goal is fat loss or gaining weight.

CHAPTER 03

Tips for Fat Loss

Lose weight without starving yourself.

The challenge with fat loss isn't knowing you need a calorie deficit – it's actually sustaining one without feeling miserable. These tips make it easier.

Eat Protein at Every Meal

High-protein meals keep you fuller for longer and reduce cravings. If every meal contains a meaningful protein source – eggs, chicken, tofu, cottage cheese, greek yogurt – you'll naturally find it easier to stay within your calorie target.

Use Lower-Calorie Swaps

- Regular yogurt → greek yogurt or cottage cheese (more protein, fewer calories).
- Juice or smoothies → whole fruit (far more filling per calorie).
- White rice → a smaller portion with extra vegetables to fill the plate.
- Full-fat sauces → tomato-based or yogurt-based alternatives.
- Soft drinks → zero-sugar alternatives (sweeteners are generally safe in moderation)

Replace Your First Meal with a Protein Shake

A protein shake gives you around 25 g of protein for roughly 120 kcal. Compared to a typical breakfast of 400–600 kcal, this frees up a significant calorie budget for the rest of the day while still delivering a solid protein hit. This is one of the simplest and most effective ways to create a comfortable deficit without feeling deprived at other meals.

Plan for Hunger, Not Just Meals

Decide in advance what you'll eat when you're hungry between meals. Having a prepared answer – a boiled egg, a rice cake, a small portion of cottage cheese – stops impulse decisions when willpower is low.

Don't Skip Meals to Compensate

Skipping a meal after eating too much earlier tends to backfire. It increases hunger and often leads to overeating later. Eat a smaller, protein-rich meal instead of skipping.

> **KEY INSIGHT**
>
> You don't need to be perfect. Eating slightly over your target one day is not a problem. The deficit is built over time – think in weekly averages, not daily perfection.

CHAPTER 04

Tips for Gaining Weight

You only need a slight surplus.

While some people struggle to lose weight, others have a hard time gaining it. These tips make it easier.

Drink Your Calories

Liquid calories are easier to consume than solid food when you're not naturally hungry. High-calorie protein shakes and smoothies can add 400–700 kcal in a single drink that takes minutes to prepare and doesn't feel like a heavy meal. A simple example: whole milk + 2 scoops protein powder + a banana + a tablespoon of peanut butter = roughly 600–700 kcal and 50–60 g of protein.

Don't Forget to Eat

It sounds obvious, but many people who struggle to gain weight simply skip meals because they're busy or not hungry. Set a reminder for each meal if needed. Three structured meals plus two snacks is a solid baseline – skipping any of them makes hitting a calorie surplus unnecessarily difficult.

Add Calorie-Dense Foods to Existing Meals

You don't necessarily need to eat a lot more food, just more calorie-dense additions. Things like olive oil, nuts, or peanut butter can boost your calorie intake without making meals much bigger.

Don't Overeat

A common mistake when trying to bulk is assuming "more is better" and pushing calories way too high. In reality, a large surplus mostly leads to faster fat gain, not faster muscle growth. Your body can only build muscle at a limited rate, so extra calories don't speed that up.

Keep your surplus modest at around 200–300 kcal per day. This is enough to support steady muscle gain without unnecessary fat gain, aiming for roughly 1 kg per month on average.

Spread Your Meals Evenly

For people who find it hard to eat large portions, spreading intake evenly across the day is more effective than having one or two very large meals. Aim for 4–5 meals of a manageable size rather than trying to eat a massive dinner to compensate for a light day.

> **KEY INSIGHT**
>
> Progress is slow. Expect to gain 0.25 kg per week. If the scale isn't moving after 2–3 weeks, simply eat more – add one extra snack or increase portions slightly. Don't overthink it.

CHAPTER 05

Practical Day Planning

A simple structure for any goal – and any diet.

The examples below show how to put the tips from Chapters 3 and 4 into an actual daily meal structure. The plans below are just examples on how you could plan your meals for a day. You can use them as a starting point and adjust portions to match your own calorie and protein targets.

Fat Loss

MEAL	EXAMPLE	~CALORIES	~PROTEIN
Breakfast	Protein shake (1 scoop whey + water)	120 kcal	25 g
Lunch	Chicken breast + rice + broccoli	520 kcal	45 g
Snack	Cottage cheese (150 g) + cucumber	140 kcal	17 g
Dinner	Salmon + sweet potato + green beans	500 kcal	38 g
Total		1,280 kcal	125 g

Fat Loss 🌱

MEAL	EXAMPLE	~CALORIES	~PROTEIN
Breakfast	Plant protein shake (1 scoop + water)	120 kcal	25 g
Lunch	Spiced lentils + brown rice + spinach	480 kcal	25 g
Snack	Soy yogurt (150 g) + berries	130 kcal	11 g
Dinner	Tofu stir-fry + broccoli + cauliflower rice	420 kcal	30 g
Total		1,150 kcal	91 g

Gaining Weight

MEAL	EXAMPLE	~CALORIES	~PROTEIN
Breakfast	Oats (100 g) + whey protein + whole milk + banana	650 kcal	35 g
Snack	High-cal shake: whole milk + 2 scoops whey + peanut butter	680 kcal	55 g
Lunch	Ground beef + pasta + tomato sauce	580 kcal	35 g
Snack	Mixed nuts + Greek yogurt (150 g)	420 kcal	20 g
Dinner	Chicken thighs + rice + olive oil drizzle	700 kcal	45 g
Total		3,030 kcal	190 g

Gaining Weight 🌱

MEAL	EXAMPLE	~CALORIES	~PROTEIN
Breakfast	Oats (100 g) + plant protein powder + almond butter + banana	650 kcal	38 g
Snack	High-cal shake: oat milk + 2 scoops plant protein + peanut butter	620 kcal	50 g
Lunch	Chickpea & brown rice bowl + tahini dressing + roasted veg	580 kcal	35 g
Snack	Mixed nuts + soy yogurt (150 g)	400 kcal	18 g
Dinner	Tempeh + rice + stir-fried greens + sesame oil	680 kcal	42 g
Total		2,930 kcal	183 g

Protein Sources

FOOD	~CALORIES per 100g	~PROTEIN per 100g
Chicken breast	165 kcal	31 g
Lean beef	217 kcal	26 g
Salmon	208 kcal	20 g
Tuna	132 kcal	24 g
Eggs	155 kcal	13 g
Cottage cheese	98 kcal	11 g
Greek yogurt	97 kcal	9 g
Tofu 🌱	134 kcal	14 g
Tempeh 🌱	193 kcal	20 g
Seitan 🌱	143 kcal	25 g
Edamame 🌱	121 kcal	11 g

CHAPTER 06

Meal Prep

Optional but Helpful

Meal prep – preparing food in advance – is not a requirement. Many people hit their goals without it. But if you find yourself reaching for fast food when you're tired or busy, having pre-prepared food removes that temptation at exactly the right moment.

What Actually Helps

You don't need to prep every single meal. Even prepping just your lunches for the week – in one 60-minute session – removes the most common decision point where plans fall apart. Batch-cooking a protein (chicken, ground beef, boiled eggs), a grain (rice, pasta, oats), and a vegetable covers most of your weekday lunches.

Basic Approach

- Pick one time per week (Sunday works for most people) for a focused 60–90 minute cook.
- Cook a large batch of protein, a grain, and some roasted vegetables.
- Portion into containers and refrigerate.
- Mix and match throughout the week – same ingredients, different sauces.
- Cooked proteins last 3–4 days in the fridge. Freeze anything beyond that.

CHAPTER 07

Frequently Asked Questions

Do I need to follow a strict meal plan?

No. A loose daily structure – knowing roughly what you'll eat at each meal – is enough to see results. Rigid plans are fragile; flexible plans stick. Aim for 80% consistency, not perfection.

Do I need to count calories?

Not necessarily, but awareness matters. If you're not getting the results you expect, tracking calories for even 2–4 weeks creates invaluable baseline knowledge. Many people significantly underestimate their intake until they measure it.

How do I handle eating out?

Plan for it. If you know you're eating out on Friday, adjust your other meals that day to leave room. When eating out, prioritise protein-rich options and be mindful of portion size. One flexible meal rarely derails progress – it's the overall pattern that matters.

What if I'm not hungry enough to hit my calorie target?

This is common for people trying to gain weight. Focus on calorie-dense foods and liquid calories rather than forcing yourself to eat larger portions. Smoothies, whole milk, nut butters, and olive oil are your most efficient tools.

What if I'm always hungry in a deficit?

Increase protein and fibre. Both are highly satiating. Adding more vegetables, legumes, and a protein source to each meal dramatically improves how full you feel for the same number of calories. Drinking water before meals also helps.

Is a cheat day fine?

Occasional higher-calorie meals or days are completely normal and won't ruin your progress. What matters most is how often they happen and how far above your calorie target you go. A small increase once in a while has very little impact, but frequent "cheat days" with very large calorie overages can easily slow or reverse progress over time.

Ready to put it into practice?

More free guides, training content, and resources at:

trenesisgym.github.io/trenesis/

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